

The Latch

Player-facing description

The Latch feels like a threshold that decides whether access is earned, bought, or refused.

Public role

Make entry feel chosen by people, not granted by map travel.

Handout text

A settlement or gateway whose name makes local access feel earned rather than purchased.

GM truth

No forced reveal. Let this entity disclose truth through scene context and player attention.

GM handling

Introduce with sensory texture, then make one discoverable clue or social choice visible.

Mechanics

- Title: Location Exploration Mechanics
- Player Safe: Players can navigate, search, read customs, inspect hazards The Latch when it is present in the fiction.
- Gm Only: Use the roll only when the player's method, stakes, and consequence are concrete.
- No Roll Reveals: Surface read: A settlement or gateway whose name makes local access feel earned rather than purchased. Give obvious visible facts freely; roll for meaning, risk, leverage, cost, or a hidden angle.
- Rolls: entity-the-latch-engage-the-latch entity-the-latch Engage The Latch Engage The Latch Instinct Knowledge Finesse Presence Instinct Knowledge, Finesse, Presence 13 Choose the trait from the player's method, not the entity type. A flat read of The Latch hides the cost, motive, or useful next step. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. A flat...
- Fear Spends: Reveal who benefits from the current situation. Make the cost personal without closing off player agency.

- Condition Options: No official condition unless a hazard creates Hidden, Restrained, or Vulnerable
- Search Loot: Search yields context first: spoor, warning marks, tool scratches, route signs, or local testimony unless a scene names treasure.

Profile

- Schema Version: location-profile-v1
- Id: the-latch
- Entity Id: the-latch
- Source: Story Atlas generated location notes
- Auto Surface: True
- Priority: strong
- Player Safe: The Latch A settlement or gateway whose name makes local access feel earned rather than purchased. A settlement or gateway whose name makes local access feel earned rather than purchased. The Latch feels like a threshold that decides whether access is earned, bought, or refused. The Latch is a crossing with personality: crank wheels, oversized locks, bridge teeth, dangling key charms, and a mechanism that seems offended by haste. The place breaks into usable table spaces: Gate bridge: The crossing narrows where the mechanism grips it. Crank platform: Controls are exposed, heavy, and tempting. Maintenance hatch: A crawl space gives clever players another route. Plants and materials: lock-moss in gear teeth, bridge weeds, dangling vine knots. Animals and background life: gear beetles, bridge swallows, crank mice. The air carries metal groan, charm clatter, bridge shudder, satisfying or...
- Block1: The Latch Make entry feel chosen by people, not granted by map travel. A settlement or gateway whose name makes local access feel earned rather than purchased. The Latch makes access relational instead of automatic. Access here is relational, not automatic. The Latch makes the party earn a crossing instead of buying one. The Latch makes access relational instead of automatic. The mechanism jams as often as it works. Patience, or a clever hand at the maintenance hatch, is what gets you through. <pages/entities/the-latch.html>
- Block2: A gate, narrow pass, or settlement edge is reinforced with practical repairs rather than show. Marks show where people wait before being invited through. The real lock is social: who vouches, who listens, and who arrives with trouble. Old scratches near the latch show forced entry has happened before. Detail Wet iron, woodsmoke, packed dirt, and old rope. Detail The latch itself is hand-worn, heavy, and warmer than the metal around it. The Latch feels like a threshold that decides whether access is earned, bought, or refused. The Latch is a crossing with personality: crank wheels, oversized locks, bridge teeth, dangling key charms, and a mechanism that seems offended by haste. The place breaks into usable table spaces: Gate bridge: The crossing narrows where the mechanism grips it. Crank platform: Controls are exposed, heavy, and tempting. Maintenance hatch: A crawl space gives clever...
- Block3: main latch waiting marks vouching post repair seams Presence to request entry with respect. Knowledge to understand repairs and old damage. Instinct to sense who is watching from cover. Local residents or workers appropriate to the place gear beetles, bridge swallows, crank mice No default combatant; add only if

- the scene introduces one Local civic, trade, or route interests Food, tools, route signs, local goods, or scene-specific clues lock-moss in gear teeth, bridge weeds, dangling vine knots controlled crossing mechanism clues shortcut if understood
- Block4: The place changes even if the PCs stand still. Local people, creatures, weather, signage, and ward behavior all keep moving around the scene. Forcing entry changes every conversation after. Being vouched for carries responsibility. The threshold can delay urgent travel. The latch opens before anyone admits they chose to open it. A watcher names the party's cargo from behind the gate. Let the place be funny through overconfident signage, awkward forms, stubborn local habits, and magic that refuses corporate language.
 - Block5: MAP-LOC-the-latch
 - Block6: Describe what the PCs can see, smell, hear, touch, ask about, or infer. Do not explain hidden infrastructure or corporate thesis until play earns it. surface A settlement or gateway whose name makes local access feel earned rather than purchased. table clue The Latch makes access relational instead of automatic. earned truth Reveal deeper system meaning through NPC answers, evidence, or player questions, not narration dumps.
 - What Here: Local residents or workers appropriate to the place gear beetles, bridge swallows, crank mice No default combatant; add only if the scene introduces one Local civic, trade, or route interests Food, tools, route signs, local goods, or scene-specific clues lock-moss in gear teeth, bridge weeds, dangling vine knots controlled crossing mechanism clues shortcut if understood
 - Living Place: location-living-place-v1 magical lock-gate crossing The Latch is a crossing with personality: crank wheels, oversized locks, bridge teeth, dangling key charms, and a mechanism that seems offended by haste. Gate bridge The crossing narrows where the mechanism grips it. Use for movement. Crank platform Controls are exposed, heavy, and tempting. Use for player action. Maintenance hatch A crawl space gives clever players another route. Use for problem solving. lock-moss in gear teeth, bridge weeds, dangling vine knots gear beetles, bridge swallows, crank mice metal groan, charm clatter, bridge shudder, satisfying or terrifying clicks The mechanism jams, gets coaxed open, collects moss, and is cleaned just enough to remain stubborn. The Latch should click, sigh, or resist whenever players assume it is only scenery. Do you force it, listen to it, inspect the hatch, ask locals, or look for...
 - Districts Or Subareas: Gate bridge The crossing narrows where the mechanism grips it. Use for movement. Crank platform Controls are exposed, heavy, and tempting. Use for player action. Maintenance hatch A crawl space gives clever players another route. Use for problem solving.
 - Sensory Signature: Detail Wet iron, woodsmoke, packed dirt, and old rope. Detail The latch itself is hand-worn, heavy, and warmer than the metal around it.
 - Visual Assets: location-visual-assets-v1 the-latch The Latch Bright comedic frontier high-fantasy concept art for a Daggerheart-adjacent tabletop RPG. Medieval/Renaissance fantasy technology only: hand tools, wagons, ropes, parchment notices, ward-stones, carved wood, brass, cloth, stone, moss, lanterns, and magic. The tone is colorful, playful, slightly absurd, and vivid, like a fantasy corporate frontier comedy rather than a grim drama. No sci-fi machinery, no 1800s/Victorian clothing, no modern suits, no guns, no logos, no readable text, no watermark, no border, no collage. /Users/kyle/Documents/My Games/Peril To Profit/story-

atlas/src/location_visual_assets/the-latch MAP-LOC-the-latch lock-gate crossing gate
mechanism map profile_scene Profile image ready /Users/kyle/Documents/My Games/Peril
To Profit/story-atlas/src/location_visual_assets/the-latch/profile_scene_v02.png...

- Imagine It Like: A drawbridge or canal lock with a mind of its own, crossed with a toll gate run by one cranky operator. Think old swing-bridge that opens when it feels like it.

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